

Chapter Thirteen

Angry tears crept down her cheeks as Autumn stormed up the stair. She would not look back no matter how much is hurt. *Don't look back. Don't look back. Do not look back.* Repeating the words like a mantra in her head was necessary to keep her dignity. Her first instinct was to fight. She needed to fight with him in order to fight for them. But why fight for someone who didn't want her. Jack didn't want to be around her. He regretted sleeping with her, and it was his loss. So why did her chest feel like it had been ripped open with a plastic butter knife. Why could she not control her emotions when that fucking faery was anywhere near her? "I belong to you". She had wanted his words mean so much more. Is this how Kamara felt about Carver? She had been catching feeling and he just wanted to check her off his to do list. Bastard! A strong wind blew through the second-floor hallway. Autumn turned to find the source of the breeze but as she rotated so did the wind. The air swirled around her, ruffling her curls.

"Autumn. Are you ok?"

The wind immediately stopped.

"Carver. Is Kamara here with you?"

"Yeah. Flying didn't agree with her," he said rubbing his flat belly. "She's at Base."

"Thank goodness she's safe. I'm glad she's here. I could really use my friend right now."

"Maybe we should get your emotions under control before you see Kamara. Looks like your powers are growing and somebody must have pissed you off."

"Powers?"

"The wind. That was you, Autumn. When we lose control of our emotions, we lose control of our powers too."

"I -- I don't know how I did that. I'm not very good at this whole magic being thing."

Autumn grabbed the gold ring on the silver chain that hung around her neck and shuffled her feet.

"It's alright. Coming into your powers is a tough time especially for a Wayward. I would be glad to show you a few things, but I'm supposed to relieve Lucky for a few hours. What has Jack showed you?"

A breeze ruffled Autumn's coil. After a few deep breaths in through the nose out through the mouth Autumn answered the question.

"Jack showed me his own powers, but I guess we haven't had time to work on my own."

"Come on" Carver said heading toward Lucky's post.

Lucky was still standing in the hall outside her mother's bedroom.

"Hey Lucky. Jack wants me to relieve you."

"Why? I told him I would take watch tonight. It's been less than an hour."

"I think you may have to do a fly by on Sage."

"Damn it. Excuse my language, Princess." Lucky said.

"Princess? Carver asked looking at Autumn with wide eyes.

"Haven't you heard? Autumn is Queen Rayvn's daughter." Lucky said with a wide smile. Taking entirely too much pleasure in dropping the princess bomb before leaving to deal with Sage.

"Please don't start acting weird. I'm just Autumn West Wayward fae and you were going to help me with my magic."

"Alright." Carver agreed after a long moment. I can't show you all the elements inside the mansion. We don't want to destroy the place, but I can show you wind and water. Do you know what your bonus power is?"

"I'm *Siliana*."

"Cool. Carver said unzipping his pack and producing a bottle of water. We'll practice

water manipulation first. You can use this same technique to control your telepathy. Look at the water and in your mind tell it what to do."

"Do I need to wave my hands around or point to it or something?"

"Your hands might help at first. It's a mental thing. When you get more comfortable you won't need hand motions."

Carver twisted open the cap and took a drink.

"I want you to pull the water out of the bottle. 'Autumn eyed the bottle with uncertainty but held out her hand above it. She squinted at the water commanding it to come out of the container. The water started to rise into the neck and out of the plastic bottle. It snaked up and out until it tickled the palm of her hand.

Autumn gasped.

"I did it." she said in disbelief.

"Yes!" Carver cheered just before the water Autumn had been controlling splashed to the floor.

Autumn worked on taming her powers for about an hour before a loud grumbling noise started to come from her stomach.

"Who knew that learning to control magical powers would work up such an appetite?" she said.

"Why do you think we eat so much?" Carter laughed. I'm sure Jack can cook something at the house for you and Kamara."

Jack didn't want to see her tonight. Maybe ever after the way he reacted to dear old grandpa. Come to think of it, Jack had been doing nothing but trying to get rid of her the whole time they were together. Maybe it was a pity fuck.

"Thanks for the offer, Carver but I'm really tired. I think I'll find something to eat here. Do you think Kamara will stop by later?"

"Yeah, she wanted to come straight here, but I asked her to wait until she feels better.

When I see her, I'll send her your way."

"Thanks. I'm on the other end of the hall."

"Hey if you want a quick snack there's always fruit in the kitchen downstairs. Make a U turn at the bottom of the stairs. You can't miss it."

Autumn found the kitchen. Of course, she couldn't miss it. It was huge. Kamara would love the white and blue stone island. She always complained that their kitchen didn't have enough counter space to spread out. This island would probably seat eight people. On the counter behind the island Autumn spotted a bowl of fruit and her stomach let out a loud rumble. An apple would have to be her dinner for tonight. Practicing magic was definitely a workout but she had to admit it was fun.

After washing her zero-calorie dinner under the kitchen faucet she took a bite not bothering to dry the fruit. This had to be her mother's touch. Her mom always made sure there were healthy snacks for Autumn to grab on the go. The memory made her smile as she headed for the stairs.

When she reached her bedroom door most of the apple was gone. Maybe she should have grabbed a banana too but there was no way she was trekking back to the kitchen.

Someone had laid a satin pajama set on her bed.

"Nice" she sighed.

She headed to the adjoining bathroom to shower and change. She had been so worried about her mom before that she'd barely had time to change clothes.

Autumn turned the knob to start the water. The warm spray felt like heaven on her skin. Not surprisingly there was shampoo, conditioner and citrus scented body wash in the shower cubby. Normally she wouldn't dare wash her hair away from home, but her coils smelled like smoke thanks to that asshole at the cabin. Nothing was normal about the last forty-eight hours, so she lathered up.

Thirty minutes later Autumn stepped out of the shower. She wrapped one soft white towel around her body and another around her hair. It would take hours to dry but she was too tired to search for a blow dryer.

There was a small bowl of berries on the nightstand by the bed. How had she missed that before getting in the shower?

"I must be really tired" she said grabbing a couple blueberries and popping them in her mouth. When she sank her teeth into the healthy snack her mouth was flooded with a bitter tasting juice. She scrunched up her face and squeezed her eyes shut at the tart taste. Her stomach cramped at the introduction of the bitter fruit. The pain started small but grew like a wave. She needed to sit down. She tried to breathe through the pain. Thankfully after a few minutes the cramping stopped, and her body relaxed.

Autumn opened her eyes and looked around. What was wrong with those berries. She had been in so much pain that she didn't even remember laying on the bed. She sat up to stretch and that's when she saw it.

A person was laying on the floor near the foot of the bed.

"Hey are you ok?" She lowered her feet to the floor and approached what seemed to be a lifeless body.

"Oh shit."

The body on the ground was her.

Lucky walked into the house to the Thump Thump Thump of someone hitting the heavy bag and he could guess who it might be.

He headed straight for the gym in the back room of the house. Jack was covered in sweat. Fists and feet flew at the heavy bag with no signs of slowing. The temperature

of the room was at least twenty degrees higher than the rest of the house. Jack's emotions were out of control. He didn't acknowledge Lucky's presence.

Lucky position himself behind the object of Jack's fury. A dangerous position for sure but his friend needed to have a conversation.

"Jack" Lucky said peering at his friend while holding the heavy bag still.

"Move."

"Jack, we need to talk."

"Move."

Jack's eyes were glowing. His emotions were out of control, but this conversation needed to happen now.

"Fine I'll talk while you continue to throw a fit."

"Fuck you"

"You need to talk to Autumn."

"Fuck off Lucky. I called you to find Sage not because I need to have a Dr. Phil moment."

"Did I hear my name?" Sage chose that moment to make her appearance.

"Where the hell have you been Sage? I called you almost an hour ago."

"I couldn't leave in the middle of my appointment." she said pointing at her fresh black and pink box braids. "I'm here now. Where's the fire?"

"Later." Lucky answered.

"You can brief her now. Somewhere else. Not here."

"Meet me in the dining room in fifteen minutes." Lucky said.

"Yes, sir." Sage responded with a grin before going to do as she was asked.

"Get the fuck out Lucky."

"She can't help who her parents are Jack. We should know that. I know what the laws say but Autumn is Wayward. Did you explain things to her before you bonded with her."

"She's the Princess!" Jack shouted striking out at the punching bag. Lucky was knocked to the ground by the explosive force and the bag was on fire. Flames were spreading from the spot on the bag where Jack had connected the punch. The blaze crawled up his arms and danced across his chest.

Jack's growl rattled the windows until Lucky was afraid, they might shatter.

Lucky rose to his full height and stretched his arms wide. In a practice motion he brought his arms together in front of his body gathering air along the way. In a rush Lucky pushed the air at Jack's fire-wrapped body. It was like blowing out a big pissed-off birthday candle. Lucky hammered his friend with wind until it was Jack's turn to fall to the floor.

Jack lay on his back with his eyes closed. Chest pumping up and down from the exertion.

"Are you trying to kill us all or just yourself? Listen to me." Lucky said reaching down to grab Jack's hand to haul him to his feet. "Autumn is a beautiful, powerful woman. From the small amount of time, I have spent with her I know she will make good queen one day and nothing is stopping you from being by her side."

"Why were you with Autumn?" Jack asked through gritted teeth.

"She was pretty upset when you left her at the mansion. She caused a windstorm in the upstairs hallway. She didn't realize she was controlling it. Carver's trying to show her how to use her magic now. Obviously, you know as well as I do that our powers are tied to our emotions." Lucky motioned to the smoldering punching bag.

"The Incubus inside me wants her. It wants to possess her. Mark her like an animal. This is why the law is in place. I have already made the mistake of letting things get out of hand. I have to end it now, before it's too late.

"You've bonded to her. That's not an Incubus thing. That's a Bakazi thing. The law is in place to keep our Incubus DNA out of the Bakazi gene pool but that may not apply to Autumn."

"What do mean? She is a Bakazi princess. The law especially applies to her."

"Why was Autumn's birth kept secret? We know that her mother is Bakazi, but what do we know about her father?"

"What are ---

Jack froze like someone had pressed the pause button on his life.

"Jack?" Lucky waved his hand in front of Jack's suddenly vacant stare. Jack's body was still standing in the gym, but his mind had been forced somewhere else.

Chapter Fourteen

Stay calm. Autumn told herself. She closed her eyes and took several deep breaths in through the nose, out through the mouth.

Wake up.

Wake up.

Another set of deep breaths.

Wake up.

Wake up!

"Why can't I wake up?"

She looked down at her body and tried to remember what happened. The last thing she remembered was getting out of shower. What happened after that? She looked at her body wrapped in a white towel. There was a two-piece pajama set laying on the bed. Someone had put it there before she made her way to her room.

Autumn looked around for any sign of a fight. If someone else had been involved she would have tried to fight them off. Nothing was out of the ordinary except a bowl of fruit was on the nightstand. "Blueberries" She had eaten an apple but was still hungry when she got out of the shower. She ate a handful of blueberries, but they were bitter. Where they really blueberries? Did someone poison her?

"Am I dead? I ate weird poison berries and now I'm...dead. I can't be dead. I just found this whole new life. No if I were dead, I would be floating away from my body or there would be a bright light or something. Right?" Autumn asked herself out loud.

She looked closely at her body this time. She had to be alive. Her back moved up and down. She was breathing but she could not just sit around and wait to be found. She didn't know how much longer her body could fight whatever she had ingested.

If she was only unconscious and not dead, she should be able to use her telepathy

and dream walk.

She had already seen how strong her connection was to Jack. No matter how he felt about her this was like and death.

Autumn closed her eyes and pictured his face. He was talking to someone.

"You've bonded to her. That's not an Incubus thing. That's a Bakazi thing." the person was saying.

"Jack."

"Jack, I need you."

The connection was not as strong as it had been the last time, she entered his thoughts.

"Autumn?" Jack responded.

"Yes. I need your help. I'm at the mansion in my room. My body is on the floor. I can't wake up. I think I'm... I'm dying.

It was taking so much strength to communicate.

"What?"

"I think someone poisoned me, Jack. Please hurry. I'm so tired."

"Hang on. I'm on my way."

Autumn hoped that Jack would be there fast enough to keep her from floating away from her body permanently.

Jack blinked his eyes as his consciousness returned. Lucky was standing in front of him with a concerned look on his face.

"It was Autumn. She's *Siliana*. Someone poisoned her. We have to get to her now."

Jack ran through the house with Lucky close behind. All he could do was picture Autumn's lifeless body on the floor. He should have never left her alone.

"What's going on?" Kamara asked as both men ran past her on the front porch.

"Autumn's hurt." Jack said without slowing his pace.

"I'm coming with you." Kamara said.

They all sprinted across the lawn. When they arrived at the front door of the mansion Jack and Lucky stood side by side in front of the grand wooden door. Jack wanted to run through the damn thing like a tank but thank the universe that Lucky was thinking clearly.

Lucky entered the security code on the keypad next to the door and they all headed inside. Jack took the stairs two at a time. Autumn could be dying, and she was scared and all alone. Why did he leave her alone?

Jack went left when he reached the landing and ran to Autumn's door.

The scene inside was like a nightmare. Autumn was lying face down on the floor and didn't appear to be breathing.

"No no no no no." Jack said as he dropped to his knees and rolled over Autumn's limp body.

"Autumn wake up baby." he pleaded while gathering her in his arms.

"Lucky get help!"

"I can help her." Kamara said sinking to her knees in front of Jack. "Lay her down flat on the floor."

Jack felt helpless as he watched his mate slip away forever. Kamara was saying something. She loved Autumn too. Did she feel like there were knives in her chest. Did Kamara feel like there was a vice around her throat? Is that what she was saying?

"I heard yelling. What's going on?"

Kamara's eyes darted toward the sound of another person entering the room.

"Someone poisoned the princess, Carver." Lucky said.

"Shit."

"Lay her down Jack. I can help her." Kamara repeated finally getting through to him.

Kamara started to rub her hands together above Autumn's body until a white light appeared between her fingers.

"What is she doing?" Carver asked.

Kamara laid one glowing hand on Autumn's belly and another on her neck.

The room fell completely silent. After a few minutes Kamara started to speak softly.

She was whispering something to the universe that was between her and the creator.

The light in Kamara's hands started to spread all over Autumn's body until she was wrapped in a cocoon of white light so bright that everyone needed to shield their eyes.

A gasp came from somewhere inside the light as it started to dim. Autumn was firmly back in the land of the living.

"Thank the universe." Jack said as he pulled Autumn back into his arms.

"I should have never left you alone."

"Promise you won't do it again." said Autumn.

Two hours later Jack, Lucky, Autumn, Carver and Kamara all sat on the leather sectional at Base. Sage was stationed in the mansion outside Queen Rayvn's door. After Autumn was revived Jack insisted on a full exam by the royal tari. Matt did as thorough an exam as he could with Autumn fully clothed. Jack had nearly needed to be restrained when Matt asked her to remove the towel she was wrapped in when they found her.

They were able to agree that Autumn wear the two-piece sleep set that had been laying on the bed. That way Matt could check her abdomen. Jack sneered at Matt the entire time, but Matt kept things very professional. Once Jack was satisfied that she was healthy he picked her up and carried her out of the mansion and back to Base. Jack refused to break contact even now. He held her hand, placed his hand on her thigh or wrapped and arm around her waist while they sat with the group on the brown leather couch.

"Those were pokeberries in your room. Easily mistaken for blueberries if you don't notice the small differences. Basically, you ingested nightshade. It's a miracle you're

alive right now. Thank you, Kamara." Jack said.

"I'm sorry I couldn't tell you about all this sooner Autumn. You had to find out about your heritage on your own. I was just around to help guide you and keep you safe."

"You saved my life Kam. You're forgiven." Autumn responded with a smile. She would have hugged her friend, but Jack had a death grip on her, and she couldn't blame him.

If she had found him half dead on the floor and had him magically brought back to life, she would probably be a little clingy. The thought of losing him made her eye sting.

"Carver you were on guard duty. Did you see anyone go into Autumn's room?" Jack asked.

"I saw a servant go into that room before she got there. A young woman with short brown hair. I've only met her briefly, but I think her name is April. I doubt she has a grudge against you. Someone ordered her to deliver those berries."

"April? I know her." Lucky chimed in.

"Why am I not surprised?" Carver asked rolling his eyes toward the ceiling.

"She's a sweet girl. Wants to be a teacher. If she delivered those berries, it was on someone else's orders. The same someone who hired that Enforcer demon. Find that person and we find our mastermind.

"You think she'll talk?"

Jack cell rang before Lucky had a chance to answer.

"What up? I'm on my way." Jack said before disconnecting the call and turning to Autumn.

"Your mother is awake and she's asking for you."

Chapter Fifteen

Autumn and Jack headed to the queen's bedroom while Lucky went to question April. The servants were usually in their rooms by this time of night. Lucky had been to the third-floor bedroom before to get visit the young lady. There was no way she was knowingly involved with trying to hurt someone.

Lucky knocked on April's bedroom door and waited for an answer that didn't come. He knocked again. Maybe she was already asleep.

"April." he called hoping to rouse her.

A crash came from the other side of the door.

Lucky turned the knob, but the door was locked tight. He took a couple of steps backward to give himself room. One kick and the door flew open to reveal a shocking scene.

The dowager King, Silas stared over his shoulder at Lucky's intrusion. He was holding a pillow over April's face as she struggled to keep breathing.

"Get off her Silas!" Lucky lunged for the other man grabbing him by the collar and pulling him free of April.

"It was you, wasn't it? You ordered April to take that fruit to Autumn's room."

April sat up on the bed coughing and gasping for air. Her olive skin was now mottled with red and purple.

"I couldn't risk the maid running her mouth."

"You son of a bitch." Lucky growled just before his fist connect with Silas's jaw.

Silas stumbled back from the force of the punch.

"April, get out of here. Go to the queen's bedroom. Tell them what happened. I'll make sure this asshole doesn't try to get away."

April eased off the bed on unsteady legs. Keeping her eyes on Silas obviously afraid

he would try to somehow finish the job that Lucky had interrupted.

"It's ok April. I got you. Go.

As April walked toward the doorway Silas made his move. Lucky caught a flash metal a second before Silas sank the dagger into Lucky's side.

April screamed and scrambled down the hallway.

Lucky went down holding his side, but he would not let this traitor take his life. Lucky kicked out just as Silas advanced to no doubt finish him off. Silas fell hard and the dagger skittered across the wood floor.

Rayvn pulled Autumn into a hug as soon as she walked through the door.

"Thank the universe you're okay. The last thing I remember is laying on the floor watching a fireball fly toward you. I couldn't move. I couldn't save you."

"Mom I'm ok. It's not your fault that some demon tried to flambé me".

"Sweetheart I don't think you are safe here. I came to the cabin to ask Jack to keep you there longer so I could... so I could look into some accusations."

"May I ask my queen what accusations?" Jack said.

Rayvn looked at Autumn with unshed tears in her eyes.

"Sit with me Autumn." Rayvn said leading Autumn toward the window seat.

"I have made so many mistakes with you and I am sorry for that. I'm sorry for not putting you first over this damn throne."

"Mom it's ok. Autumn answered softly. You did what you thought you had to. You tried to keep me safe from the Incubus the only way you knew how."

"The Incubus are not the only threat to you."

Knock Knock.

Sage opened the door without waiting for a response.

"I'm sorry to interrupt your highness but she says its urgent."

"Your Highness. The royal guard is needed. Lucky is in my room, and he's been hurt."

"What?" asked Sage before giving anyone else time to respond.

"Lucky saved my life. King Silas... he came to my room while I slept and put a pillow over my face. He tried to kill me. He's fighting with Lucky in my room. You have to help him.

Stay here with the queen and princess Jack ordered.

"No." Rayvn and Autumn answered simultaneously.

We do not have time for this. Lucky could be dying.

"Where is Sage?"

"Damnit Sage!" he called knowing where she was headed.

He could already feel the air shifting as he jogged up the stairs. Someone had started a windstorm on the third floor.

"Watch out!" Lucky yelled. A second later Sage and Lucky literally flew out of the room like a clumsy Superman and Wonder Woman then crashed into the other side of the hall in a tangle of arms and legs.

"Silas!" Jack yelled.

"Bring me Autumn West and I will let your friends live."

Jack wanted to rush in and rip Silas' throat open with his teeth, but he had to keep a level head. They were already down two people. Lucky and Sage still lay in a heap where they had crashed. The one thing he couldn't do was let Autumn walk in that room.

"Mikeal if you can hear me. You were right. Autumn needs you." Rayvn said quietly with her eyes closed. The queen was sending out a telepathic distress signal.

Good. Silas was crazed and they could use all the help they could get.

"Father, can I come in and talk to you? I want to hear your side of things."

"No, Your Highness. He's out of his mind."

"He won't hurt me, Jack. Just keep Autumn safe. I know you care for her. It's ok. If I

had listened to my heart instead of some stale law none of this would be happening. I need to try and fix this."

"I don't like you going in there, but your request is law. I can't stop you."

"Mom"

"It's going to be ok Autumn. Stay with Jack and wait for me. I love you."

"Dad I'm coming in."

Rayvn walked into April's room with her palms turned outward at her sides.

"Why are you doing this? Autumn is innocent. She's your grandchild."

"No! She's an abomination. You should have come to your mother and me. We could have gotten rid of it."

"No. Father. Autumn is a gift. She's a symbol of love."

"Blasphemy. She's a stain on the royal blood line. For years the Bakazi royal family has staid pure of blood and magic. I will not argue this truth and if you can't see that then you are no daughter of mine."

"Daddy."

The movement was so quick there was no time to react.

Silas held the dagger low and plunged it into Rayvn's belly.

Rayvn gasped and fell to the floor pressing both hands to her abdomen.

"Mikeal" Rayvn groaned as she falls to the floor.

"No" Silas said in disbelief.

Black mist appeared on the third-floor landing and all hell was truly about to break loose.

"Rayvn!" Mikeal yelled racing toward the lifeless body on the floor. As he fell to the floor beside Rayvn, he let out the ear-splitting howl of an animal in mortal pain. He cradled her head in his lap and caressed her face.

Silas stood in shock like a statue. The dagger in his hand stained with Rayvn's blood.

"Daughter?" Silas said dumbfounded.

Mikeal's head snapped up at the sound of Silas's voice. The room started to shake. No not just the room, the entire house was moving. Mikeal's shattered brown irises glowed. The lava like abnormalities that caused his eyes to resemble shattered glasses traveled down his cheek like tears. The light fixtures in the room began to spark and explode. He swiped his hand toward the dowager king and Silas floated up to the ceiling. His feet kicked underneath his ever-present dark robes and he started to claw at his neck desperate for air.

Mikeal clenched his outstretched hand into a loose fist and held Silas in place ignoring his sickly chocking sounds.

Jack threw his body over Autumn to shield her from the chaos. This was a pissed off full blood Incubus. He had to protect Autumn long enough to get her out of this house. The chaos calmed for a moment as Mikeal looked at Rayvn and began to speak.

"Do not give up Pretty Wings. Remember who you belong to body and soul. You will not leave me. I will not permit it."

"Look after our daughter. Keep her safe. I love you both."

"No! Mom!" Autumn cried reaching out for her mother.

Jake wrapped his arms around her giving as much support as he could.

Mikeal closed his eyes and lay Rayvn's head gently on the floor still holding his left hand outstretched toward Silas.

"Jack get Autumn out of here."

"Yes sir."

Jack gathered Autumn in his arms and headed for the doorway.

When his daughter was safely out of the room, he raised his other fist toward Silas.

"You took what is mine."

Mikeal began to lower his fist slowly and Silas let out a hoarse scream as his flesh was ripped open at the top of his head and peeled from his skull. Mikeal continued

taking pleasure in the screams as the musculature of Silas' lower jaw was exposed. Silas was a snake shedding its skin. Before he could pass out from the pain Mikeal jerked his head to the side using his powers to snap Silas' neck and let his limp body fall to the ground.

Mikeal knelt down next to Rayvn's body and gathered her in his arms before disappearing in a cloud of black smoke.

Jack hurried down the stairs with Autumn in his arm with no destination in mind. He only knew he had to get her away from this building.

"I knew this would happen. My love is dead because of you."

"Vervina what are saying?" Jack asked.

The elder raised her hand toward Autumn. That was when Jack saw the gun.

"Put me down." Autumn said.

Jack followed Autumn's request not because he wanted to but because he would need his hands free if he was going to stop Vervina. As soon as Autumn's feet were on the floor, he stepped in front of her.

"She killed Silas! I told him this would happen. I saw his death in a vision. I begged him to try another way. He never listened to me when it came to you. You will be a plague on the Bakazi people.

"Listen to me Vervina. "Autumn did not kill Silas. He went mad and murdered his own daughter. Queen Rayvn is dead. I should have killed him, but Silas was still breathing when we left the room."

"No. He would never hurt Rayvn."

"He stabbed my mother." Autumn said from her position behind Jack.

Good girl Jack thought. Stay out of sight and stay alive.

"I don't know what he told you but he's not who you think he is. Don't believe his lies. Let me get Autumn out of here safely."

"If the Queen is dead Autumn West will take the throne with her tainted blood. I cannot trust a demon spawn to lead my people. She has to die."

Jack charged at Vervina as the gun went off. He barely felt the sting as a bullet pierced his arm. Jack crashed into Vervina they went down hard and Vervina went still. Her eyes where frozen in a blank stare and blood started to pool around her head.

Chapter Sixteen

Autumn stared into the mirror of her mom's antique dresser. She had been told the dresser used to belong to her grandmother, Olive. She asked Jack and Carver to move it to Base for her while the mansion was being repaired. Her father had done some "redecorating" before he ultimately killed Silas. The stress of nearly dying had brought about her transition in full force. Her curls were as unruly as ever but now had red highlights like her mom's and that wasn't the only change in her appearance. Her eyes had lightened to the same amber shade as her father's and her lips seemed fuller too. Though that may have been due to the addition of her brand-new fangs. Two days after the attack she had gone to bed with a headache and woken up forty-eight hours later with Jack and Kamara at her bedside. They explained what had happened and patiently answered her questions.

Four weeks had passed since Autumn's life was turned upside down. She'd nearly been killed by her grandfather and his mistress but thanks to Jack and the rest of the Kin Squad she was still on the right side of the dirt. It was hard to believe they had known each other for so little time. Meeting Jack had changed her entire life. Well, that wasn't exactly true. Learning about her heritage had changed her life but Jack was the one who had dropped the truth bomb. She had gotten to spend time with her mother. Her best friend turned out to be magical and in a broken relationship with a faery slash demon. But she knew their situation would work itself out.

Now Autumn had a group of people that she considered family. She knew they would look out for her, and she would do her best to look out for them.

Lucky and Sage saw her mother being taken away by her father, the Incubus. She was still coming to grips with the fact that she was not only a faery but part demon too. Incubus were not known to fall in love according to the Bakazi, but her mother had spoken as if they had a short-lived romance. According to Sage and Lucky her

mom's body was unmoving when she was taken, but Autumn needed closure. If there was any chance to have more time with her mom Autumn wanted it.

Lately she had been dreaming about her father. Though she had the feeling that she was not controlling those dreams. They were always in her mom's bedroom. The location made her feel safe and she had a feeling her father knew that. The first night he had visited her dream and introduced himself as Mikeal. He said that he would always watch over her.

The next week he returned saying that he wanted Autumn to ascend to the throne. That it was what Rayvn wanted. Autumn agreed to do so temporarily. The Bakazi deserved a leader until their queen could return.

Two weeks later Mikeal made a return. Autumn asked him again if her mother was alive. Maybe she was recuperating from her stab wound. He refused to reply saying it would be his last visit for a while. He said that he trusted Jack to watch over Autumn for a little while but that they would see each other again.

"We will find her, *Kipeyo*."

"What?"

"Your mother. I know you are thinking of her when you stare into her mirror."

"I need to find her Jack. I need to be sure this time."

Jack wrapped his arms around her from behind and put his face next her own.

"I know. The Kin Squad is checking all our sources. We will find her."

It felt so good to have him wrapped around her. Safe and quiet. The concerns of the world melted away when she was in his arms.

"I love you."

"And I love you, Autumn West. My partner, my mate, my princess."

Autumn smiled and turned in his arms wrapping her arms around his neck to pull him in for a kiss.

Jack deepened their kiss and slid his hands down her curves, pressing himself even

closer to her. The satin of her robe only enhanced the feel of his touch on the naked skin beneath. She moaned into his kiss and pressed her chest against his.

Jack gripped her thighs and lifting her to sit on the dresser. Autumn had to spread her legs until they were nearly flat against the hardwood surface to accommodate his size. The position turned her on even more. Autumn nuzzled against his naked chest for a second before pulling him in for another kiss. This time she grazed his bottom lip with her teeth.

Autumn reached for Jack's pants.

"Thank the universe for an elastic waistband. Easy access."

Just a little tug and her prize sprang free. She would never get tired of the feel of him in her hands. Soft and hard at the same time. As she started to stroke him Jack growled.

"Enough *Kipeyo*."

"You never let me play." Autumn pouted.

"We have a lifetime for you to play. Remember I belong to you, and you belong to me." Jack said sinking into her. Autumn wrapped her legs around him pulling him as deep into her as she could.

"Why do you still call me *Kipeyo*? You've touched every part of me."

"And I will never stop touching this gorgeous body. But you are better left untouched by another unless he wants to lose whichever part touched my beautiful butterfly."

Autumn smiled up at Jack as he started to move inside her. His overprotectiveness was unnecessary but sexy as hell because she felt the same way about him.

Jack was right they would have a lifetime together because he belonged to her, and she belonged to him.

Trigger Warnings

Turn the page if you don't mind spoilers.

This book contains the following content that may be difficult for some readers:

Adult Language

Biting

Choaking

Graphic Violence

Nudity

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